Secretary-General Ban Ki-moon has praised his ‘vision, leadership and courage to put Myanmar on the path to change’.[135] As such, the relative liberalism of the period 2011–14 (a period without any electoral events that could threaten USDP control) can be seen as a deliberate strategy designed to maximise international investment and gain legitimacy.

There is evidence this has worked so far. Many external bodies seem to want to believe that Myanmar is becoming more democratic and any problems are the minor setbacks that accompany the process of moving from an authoritarian regime to a democratic one. This is a dangerous assumption and the reality remains that Myanmar’s future success depends on it respecting the rights of all of its citizens, especially those from the most persecuted groups.[136] As the refugee outflows in 2015 have shown, the persecution of the Rohingyas has the capacity to undermine the stability of much of the neighbouring region. Progress is not just about the convenient veneer of regular elections.

Still, the fact that recent years have seen substantial flows of international capital into Myanmar is hugely significant, because it gives the international community leverage to comment on the country’s domestic politics, and allows us to intervene on behalf of the oppressed minorities—should we commit to doing so. All regimes take some note of international opinion—and at this point in their history specifically, Myanmar is more responsive to international opinion than at any time since it has gained independence. At the moment, in the rush to praise the limited moves towards democracy[137] and to ensure a share of the investment boom, foreign states are not fulfilling their moral, and arguably legal (under UN legislation), obligation of holding the regime to account for ongoing abuses against minorities.

As in other recent instances of genocide, such as Rwanda, international indifference to the realities of a country is dangerous. If the regime feels it has no reason to fear external pressure, it is more likely to indulge in further, perhaps escalated, repression. Rohingya activists are clear that the Myanmar regime will only agree to intervene against their persecution if threatened by international sanctions. To the regime, building up the economy is the means to a strong military. As one activist told me, ‘When I talk to the … people with the ruling party … their interest is to … make Myanmar economically strong [because] if the economy’s not strong, defence is not strong. Because they love the word of a British defence